

STARTER

Common Refusal Reasons & How to Avoid Them

United Kingdom - Student Visa

Student visa refusals are decided against Appendix Student of the Immigration Rules. Unlike the Visitor route, the Student route is points-based and depends heavily on your CAS being valid and your financial evidence meeting a specific, published formula - which makes exact detail matching far more important here than a general narrative.

The most common specific reasons

1. CAS details don't match the application

Your name, passport number, date of birth, course title, or sponsor details on the application don't exactly match what your sponsor submitted on your CAS.

- Double-check every field against your CAS statement (your sponsor can usually provide a copy) before submitting
- If your passport has been renewed since your CAS was issued, tell your sponsor so they can update the CAS - don't just enter the new passport number and hope it reconciles automatically

2. Financial evidence doesn't meet the maintenance requirement

- The required amount (course fees payable, plus a fixed monthly living-cost figure for up to 9 months) is a formula, not a judgement call - see the Financial Requirements Overview for exactly how it's calculated
- Funds must be held for a consecutive 28-day period, ending no more than 31 days before you apply - a balance that dips below the required amount at any point in that window, even briefly, can fail the requirement
- The account and evidence must meet the specific acceptable-evidence rules (type of account, the specific documents accepted) - a technically sufficient balance in an unacceptable form of evidence can still be refused

3. Not a “Genuine Student”

A caseworker (sometimes following a credibility interview) isn't satisfied your intention is genuinely to study the specific course, that it represents a credible next step given your history, or that you intend to leave the UK or switch to a further permitted route at the end of your permission.

- Be able to clearly explain why this course, this institution, and how it fits your academic or career plans - this matters more if you're asked to interview
- If you're switching routes, make sure your new course represents genuine academic progression from your last one - the Rules specifically test for this

4. Missing ATAS certificate

Certain postgraduate research courses (commonly in STEM, engineering, and some technology fields) require an Academic Technology Approval Scheme (ATAS) certificate for applicants of relevant nationalities, obtained separately before you apply. Check with your sponsor whether your specific course requires one - it isn't universal to all postgraduate study.

5. Incomplete or inconsistent immigration history

- Disclose all previous visas, extensions, refusals, and any overstay or breach honestly
- If you're already in the UK, your record is checked directly against Home Office systems - inconsistencies are easy to detect

A REFUSAL ISN'T FINAL

There's no formal right of appeal for most Student visa refusals, but Administrative Review may apply in specific circumstances, or you can reapply with a stronger case once your CAS or evidence is fixed. See the Refusal Decision Guide (Premium tier).